

ONLY AN AXE AWAY

ONLY AN AXE AWAY (DOCUMENTARY)

(ORU MAZHU DOORAM MATHRAM)

BY P, BABURAJ AND C. SARAT CHANDRAN

A BRIEF OF THE DOCUMENTARY:

This documentary tells the story of the unique campaign to save the SILENT VALLEY from destructive development. In the 1970s, the state government planned to construct a hydro-electric dam on the fringes of the Park at Pathrakadavu across Kunthipuzha River. This project would have flooded large parts of the rainforest, destroying its rare plants and animals. The documentary highlights the valley's rich biodiversity. It is home to many endangered species that includes leopards, tiger, lion-tailed macaque (simha vaalan kurang), Nilgiri langur (karimkurang) and Nilgiri tahr (The Nilgiri tahr (Nilgiritragus hylocrius) is an ungulate species endemic to the Nilgiri Hills and parts of the Western and Eastern Ghats in southern India. It is the only mountain ungulate found in this region and is designated as the state animal of Tamil Nadu. The species is currently listed as endangered, with its largest population found in Eravikulam National Park.). All the 50 species of endemic (regional) birds found in the entire Western Ghats are present in the Silent Valley. These animals would have faced extinction if the dam had been built. This short film shows how people came together to protect the forest. Scientists, nature lovers and local communities led the movement. They organized protests, raised awareness and shared with the world the importance of the SILENT VALLEY. Their message was clear: some places are too precious to lose. Through powerful visuals and interviews, the film explains how this movement gained support. It became one of India's great environmental campaigns. The pressure grew and the government had to give in. In 1984, the dam project was stopped. The SILENT VALLEY was declared a National Park, safe from destruction. ONLY AN AXE AWAY is a story of hope and determination. It shows the importance of protecting nature and the species that depend on it. The documentary shares anxieties of people of Kerala about the future of the SILENT VALLEY. The film reminds us that even small actions can make a big difference in saving our planet.

EXERCISES:

1. What is the primary environmental concern highlighted in "Only an Axe Away"?

Ans: The primary environmental concern highlighted in "Only an Axe Away" is the worries of Keralans regarding the future of the Silent Valley, emphasizing the impact of development and deforestation on this ecologically significant area.

2. Who are the key groups opposing the hydroelectric project in the Silent Valley?

Ans: The key groups opposing the hydroelectric project in the Silent Valley include the Kerala Sasthra Sahithya Parishad (KSSP) and the Silent Valley Movement, which is a social movement that emerged in Kerala, India, to protect the Silent Valley from being flooded by the project.

3. What role does the local community play in the fight to protect the Silent Valley?

Ans: The local community plays a crucial role in the fight to protect the Silent Valley. They have been actively involved in movements that advocate for their rights, preventing displacement, and promoting sustainable practices within the region. Their engagement has been pivotal in the broader Silent Valley movement, which aimed to protect the forest from destructive development and maintain the ecological balance of the area.

4. How does the documentary “Only an Axe Away” depict the government’s stance on the Silent Valley project?

Ans: The documentary “Only an Axe Away” portrays the government's stance on the Silent Valley project as dismissive of local concerns and environmental implications. It highlights the fears of Keralans regarding the ecological impact and the struggle against the government-supported construction of a hydroelectric project in the Silent Valley, which is home to a unique ecosystem. The film emphasizes local activism and the tensions between governmental plans and environmental preservation.

5. What is the significance of the Silent Valley in terms of biodiversity?

Ans: Silent Valley National Park is significant for its rich biodiversity, hosting at least 34 species of mammals, many of which are threatened. It also boasts over 128 species of butterflies and 400 species of moths, along with various rare species of flora. The area has become a crucial hub for biodiversity preservation, raising public awareness about conservation efforts.

6. What was the ultimate outcome for the Silent Valley in the battle against the hydroelectric project?

Ans: The ultimate outcome for the Silent Valley in the battle against the hydroelectric project was successful; a people's movement effectively prevented the construction of a hydroelectric dam across the Kunthipuzha River, leading to the protection of the area. In recognition of its ecological significance, the valley was declared Silent Valley National Park in 1985.

Answer the following questions in a paragraph:

7. Discuss the scientific and environmental arguments presented in “Only an Axe Away” regarding the preservation of Silent Valley. How do these arguments contrast with the government’s position on development?

Ans: The documentary *Only an Axe Away* vividly portrays the clash between ecological preservation and developmental priorities, ultimately serving as a cautionary tale about the long-term consequences of prioritizing short-term economic gains over environmental stewardship. It underscores the need for more balanced and sustainable development approaches that respect both human and environmental needs. *Only an Axe Away* presents compelling scientific and environmental arguments for the preservation of Silent Valley, emphasizing its unique biodiversity, ecological significance, and the potential catastrophic consequences of deforestation. The film highlights the area's rich flora and fauna, which could be irreparably harmed by development projects, thus advocating for conservation over exploitation. In contrast, the government's position on development often prioritizes economic growth and infrastructure expansion, arguing that such projects are essential for progress and development, potentially dismissing the environmental costs involved. This clash reflects a broader tension between ecological sustainability and economic ambition.

8. Explain the role of local communities in the documentary “Only an Axe Away”. How do their perspectives on conservation differ from those of environmentalists and scientists, and what is their impact on the movement?

Ans: In the documentary “Only an Axe Away,” local communities play a crucial role in the conservation narrative, showcasing their deep connection to the land and natural resources. The film highlights the concerns of Keralans over the future of the Silent Valley, portraying their perspectives as grounded in immediate, practical experiences rather than abstract ecological principles. These communities often prioritize their livelihoods, cultural practices, and immediate environmental needs, which can differ from the more formal approaches taken by environmentalists and scientists, who may focus on broader ecological theories or long-term conservation strategies. The impact of local communities on the conservation movement is significant, as they bring vital firsthand knowledge and alternative views that challenge top-down conservation efforts. Their involvement underscores the importance of inclusive dialogues in conservation, integrating local and indigenous knowledge into environmental decision-making processes.

9. In what ways does “Only an Axe Away” explore the conflict between economic development and environmental preservation? Discuss the challenges faced by both sides and their arguments for or against the hydroelectric project?

Ans: “Only an Axe Away” explores the tension between economic development and environmental preservation through the lens of a hydroelectric project in Kerala, India. Supporters of the project argue that it promises substantial economic benefits, including job creation, increased energy supply, and enhanced infrastructure, which are essential for the region's development. Conversely, opponents raise concerns about the environmental

impacts, including deforestation, displacement of local communities, and loss of biodiversity. They argue that the long-term ecological costs could outweigh the short-term economic gains. The film showcases the emotional and social ramifications of the project, highlighting the challenges faced by both sides in reconciling the need for progress with the imperative of protecting the environment.

10. How does the book “Only an Axe Away” complement the documentary by providing deeper historical and cultural context about the Silent Valley? Discuss the ways in which both forms of media address the issue of preserving natural resources in India?

Ans: The book "Only an Axe Away" complements the documentary of the same name by providing a more in-depth examination of the historical and cultural contexts surrounding the Silent Valley. While the documentary offers a visual portrayal of the issues at stake, including the impact of deforestation and conservation efforts, the book delves deeper into the narratives of local communities, their relationship with the land, and the broader socio-political dynamics that affect resource management in India. Both the book and the documentary highlight the urgent need for preserving natural resources, focusing on the balance between development and environmental sustainability. They address the consequences of ecological degradation and the importance of protecting unique ecosystems like the Silent Valley, emphasizing community involvement and the need for policy changes to safeguard these areas for future generations.

11. Reflect on the use of story-telling in “Only an Axe Away” (both the documentary and the book). How do the filmmakers and the author use personal narratives and scientific facts to create a compelling argument for conservation?

Ans: In "Only an Axe Away," both the documentary and the book leverage storytelling to weave personal narratives with scientific facts, effectively advocating for environmental conservation. The filmmakers and author present firsthand accounts of local communities impacted by the proposed dam project in Kerala, creating an emotional connection that underscores the human side of environmental struggles. These personal stories highlight the cultural, social, and ecological stakes involved, making the narrative relatable and urgent. Simultaneously, the inclusion of scientific evidence concerning ecological impacts, biodiversity, and sustainability challenges reinforces the argument. This combination of emotional engagement and factual grounding creates a compelling narrative that seeks to mobilize support for conservation efforts. By merging personal experiences with broader environmental data, the work effectively illustrates the importance of protecting natural resources against exploitative projects.

Essay Questions:

12. In the context of “Only an Axe Away”, analyze the ethical dilemmas surrounding the construction of dams and the preservation of natural environments. Discuss the balance between technological development, economic growth and ecological sustainability?

Ans: The ethical dilemmas surrounding the construction of dams and the preservation of natural environments revolve around the tension between technological development and ecological sustainability. On one hand, dams are seen as vital for economic growth, providing essential resources such as hydroelectric power, irrigation, and flood control. They can significantly enhance a nation’s infrastructure, supporting industrial and agricultural needs, which in turn can lead to job creation and improved living standards.

However, the environmental costs are profound. The construction of dams often leads to the flooding of vast areas, disrupting local ecosystems and displacing communities. The alteration of natural water cycles can have dramatic effects on wildlife and biodiversity, leading to habitat destruction and the endangerment of species. Additionally, the accumulation of sediments behind barriers can affect water quality and fish populations, hindering the very ecosystems that depend on the natural flow of rivers.

Therefore, the challenge lies in finding a balance that allows for technological advancement and economic benefits while maintaining ecological integrity. Sustainable development practices, such as employing smaller, more environmentally friendly alternatives or implementing effective mitigation strategies, can help alleviate some of these tensions. The concept of "green infrastructure" emerges as a possible solution that emphasizes resilience and adaptability in managing natural resources without compromising ecological health.

In conclusion, striking a balance between economic growth through infrastructure like dams and the imperative of ecological sustainability involves careful consideration of a variety of ethical, environmental, and social factors. Dialogue among stakeholders—government, developers, local communities, and environmentalists—is crucial to navigate these complex dilemmas.

13. Examine the role of public activism in the success of environmental campaigns, using “Only an Axe Away” as a case study. Discuss the challenges and strategies that activists employ to influence policy and public opinion, particularly in the context of India’s development trajectory?

Ans: Public activism plays a crucial role in the success of environmental campaigns, especially in contexts like India where development often conflicts with ecological sustainability. The documentary "Only an Axe Away," directed by activists P. Baburaj

and C. Saratchandran, serves as a poignant case study that highlights the intersection of environmental activism, community mobilization, and policy advocacy.

Activists in India face significant challenges, including bureaucratic hurdles, economic pressures, and the often conflicting interests of development versus conservation. The film illustrates how local communities, particularly marginalized groups, mobilize to protect their natural resources against encroachment. The activists in "Only an Axe Away" showcase strategies that include grassroots organizing, raising awareness through media, and coalition-building with other environmental groups and NGOs. This multifaceted approach aims to influence both public opinion and policy decisions at various governmental levels.

The filmmakers emphasize storytelling as a vital tool in activism, capturing personal narratives that resonate with a broader audience. By humanizing the environmental struggle, they effectively galvanize public support and bring attention to the often-overlooked repercussions of development projects on local ecosystems and communities.

Moreover, in India's rapid development trajectory, balance is frequently sought between economic growth and environmental protection, making activism even more relevant. Strategies such as boycotts, peaceful protests, and legal challenges are not uncommon, as activists strive to hold government and corporations accountable. However, these efforts often require significant resilience and solidarity within communities facing displacement or exploitation.

In summary, "Only an Axe Away" exemplifies how public activism is crucial in shaping environmental campaigns in India, demonstrating that collective action, strategic communication, and resilience are essential in overcoming challenges posed by development pressures and influencing public policy.

